might have been experiencing a dip in form, but no-one with any idea about soccer thinks he's anything but a world-class player. And, more to the point, no-one with any feel for United would even begin to question an amazing career at the club just because the team as a whole wasn't firing like it should. I wouldn't, for a minute, say supporters don't have the right to speak their mind about United; after all, they pay the players' wages and those of everybody else working at Old Trafford. The players have to live up to the fans' highest expectations of them, it's their job. Having a go at one player like that, though, I don't understand. It just makes things more difficult for that player and for the rest of the team. In general, I'd say the Old Trafford crowd is more patient than most. They know the game and they know the players. Real United fans knew Giggsy would be back flying, as he proved during the last six months of that season, on our way to winning the League.

When it comes to England, ever since I've been involved at least, there's always been that same tendency to lump everything onto one bloke's shoulders when the team's seen to fall short. When you think that we're representing our country, not just our clubs, on international duty—and that millions of supporters are watching on television every time we kick a ball at a major tournament—you realize that being the one to carry the burden is even more painful and humiliating. I remember, when we were younger, some of us would turn up to prepare for England games and half joke about who we thought would be to blame this time if we lost. Looking back now, it wasn't even half funny. I think players being made scapegoats didn't just undermine the particular lads who were singled out for the abuse. I think it held back the England team as a whole. And maybe it still does.

There's always pressure on the England players and I understand that: I'm patriotic, too. I'm an England fan and I want us to do well as a country. But in World Cups and European Championships, I think that pressure sometimes makes players scared to try things, makes them nervous about taking risks and really expressing themselves. It's a fear of failing and the memory of what happened to me in 1998, for example, or Phil Neville at Euro 2000 is in the back of some players' minds. Look at Brazil: they're relaxed whatever's happening. I remember, during the World Cup quarter-final in 2002, looking across the field—this was while we were 1–0 up—and Ronaldo was having a laugh and a joke with the referee.

Of course, none of the Brazilian lads are going to go back to Brazil to play their club soccer the following season: maybe that helps them not worry about what might happen if things go wrong. England players know what kind of abuse they can get and I really believe that being nervous about it